# Shattered

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Wake, gasping for air.

Your head is beating itself up, and your ears are ringing. What happened? You look at your hands, your bloody, scarred hands. Questions flood your mind, but the pounding in your head stifles any attempt at clearly thinking. You look around at your surroundings, finding yourself in an endless, pitch-dark cave with no conceivable escape.

You cradle your head in your hands, feeling hopeless. Tears, uninvited, cascade down your face like tiny rivers. The rivers become waterfalls, flowing faster and more robust. As you sob, a derisive, strange voice fills up the darkness of the grim place you find yourself in.

"Crying already? You weak little creature, this is just the beginning!" a voice says out of the darkness. You try speaking, but your brain seems to have forgotten how to. Just like how you've forgotten who you are…

Attempts to shout for help yield only to silence, but beneath it, you hear the faint flow of water. You suddenly realize how thirsty you are and try to get up again. As you slowly, shakily rise, your feet tremble as if they already know your fate.

You desperately rush towards the sound, stumbling and tripping, before reaching a tiny puddle of water. Before you can gather the seemingly undrinkable water, you slip back in shock at your reflection in the small pool. You don't remember what you look like, but your appearance looks as inhuman as a monster.

Your eyes are bloodshot, like the gore dripping down your naked body. Your skin is as frighteningly pale as a ghost, and there are fresh, still-bleeding wounds scattered across your face. You start taking deep breaths, calming yourself down. You take a sip of the water, gagging

at its sour taste. You gulp it down and drink more, cringing but desperate for more to satisfy your thirst.

"Oh look, the little rat found some water! Isn't that just lovely?" rings the same voice, mocking your miniscule discovery. It sounds like your pain and suffering... amuses it? You try shouting something back, not knowing what, but your efforts are in vain, and nothing comes out of your mouth.

You start running, sprinting, not knowing why or where you're going but just wanting to escape that voice. Your ears are filled with laughter, cold, harsh, cruel laughter. It gets louder and louder the further you run. "You useless idiot. You're just wasting your energy. Don't you realize that I will always follow you? ALWAYS!" it echoes.

Tears litter the ground as you jog, your feet stumbling and begging you to stop running, so you do. You collapse on the rough ground, exhausted, and you sense the metallic, bitter taste of blood. You run your fingers through your hair, leaving your hands bloodier and dustier than before.

"Confused? I wouldn't expect anything less from someone as weak as you," the voice taunts. You lie down, thinking in vain about this torture, this unbearable pain. "Given up, have you? Ha! You really are helpless!" The voice says. You feel like crumbling into dust. How will you ever escape this place, this prison, and be free?

You start to get up, staring straight into the apparent black abyss. You make your face look intimidating, trying to challenge whoever - no, whatever is insulting you. The voice speaks again, filled with pure loathing. "Oh? Do you think you can fight me? You can't even face me! Just look at you, you tiny, stupid little thing!"

You try saying something, anything, your efforts once again futile, and you raise your fists as if threatening the voice. Your head throbs once more, but you ignore it, knowing this pain is nothing compared to your confusion.

"Don't you get it? How will you fight me if you can't even face me?" You remain in that persistent pose, stubbornly refusing to believe the voice, daring it to appear. "Fine, you want me to come out? Just watch," it says.

Suddenly, your surroundings change. You are no longer in an endless cave but a sharp, angular room with obsidian-colored walls surrounding you. You raise your trembling fists higher, but your legs stubbornly refuse to support you. Chuckling starts sounding, first a whisper but soon loud enough to make your ears ring again. Suddenly, a pair of brown eyes appear in the darkness. Brown eyes... brown... they trigger a small glimmer of recognition.

You try vocalizing the billion questions racing through your mind, but the voice interrupts your fruitless attempt to speak. "What, you don't like my eyes?" it chortles. "How about my mouth?" A smile appears beneath the eyes as if a face is forming. If you ever tried smiling or even could smile, would your face look like that?

You start stepping back, regretting your decision to try and fight your tormentor. "Leaving so soon? Why don't you stay and play?" the voice asks, shaking with laughter. As the face changes, you stand incapacitated, forced to watch what happens next.

Soon enough, a body starts to materialize. First, hands, hands like your hands, but without the dirt and blood. Then legs, like your legs but not as broken. The person compels you to come closer despite your fear and anxiety.

The form seems to glow brighter, but not like a divine white light, more like a dark energy that hurts your eyes. It grows brighter and brighter until it emits a piercing scream, an eerie shriek of dread, horror, and pain, just like the pain it has inflicted on you. Suddenly, the figure disappears, and your vision is plunged into darkness.

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You jolt awake, gasping for breath. The echoes of the cave, the mocking voice, and the strange room are still fresh in your memory, but now you seem to be in… a forest. The towering

trees surround you, and the soothing sounds of rustling leaves and distant birds chirping replace the haunting darkness. You take a moment to gather your thoughts, the disorientation slowly fading away.

You peek at your hands scaredly, which, once bloody and scarred, now appear normal. You flex your fingers, half-expecting the pain to return, but there's only a faint ache. You realize you remember who you are, your name, age, everything, and the memories fit into you like a long-lost puzzle piece in an unfinished jigsaw. You walk around, lost, not knowing how to escape the woods that encircle you.

After a few minutes of walking, you come across a lake. You gaze at your reflection, and you step back in shock. The image, rippling in the water, is a replica of the body trying to take shape... back in that room. You start shaking uncontrollably.

"No," you murmur, the word escaping your lips with a tremor. Your voice is cracked as if you haven't used it for an eternity, but it is the same voice that had been tormenting, torturing, taunting you.

Were you that voice? Were you the one mocking yourself? How is that possible? You are filled with emotion as your brain starts whirring, trying to make sense of everything. You were trapped inside that - that place... it's like you were trapped inside yourself... It's like you were trapped inside your own mind...